The Assistant

by Don Trickseven

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by Don Trickseven

(*At rise, Drew is hunched on the couch, in extreme anxiety. His wife, Mel, is caressing him, trying to soothe him and talk him through his crisis.*)

Mel: Let's get this straight.

Drew: I'm not sure that's possible.

Mel: You know what you saw.

Drew: I'm not sure I do.

Mel: You saw Coach Wennum...

Drew: I think I saw him. I was close enough, that I think it was him.

Mel: And he was with a girl?

Drew: This girl, I think, her name is Cassandra. I know it was her, because she was the one who got involved with Calvin during the Conference Tournament last year, and we had to talk to her.

Mel: The cheerleader, right.

Drew: She's a senior.

Mel: Ok.

Drew: She's an adult. They're both adults.

Mel: Coach Wennum is 48.

Drew: If it was Coach.

Mel: Honey, you spend 8 hours a day with Coach. You'd know him from across the arena.

Drew: Yeah. I guess.

Mel: But what happened?

Drew: I think that...

Mel: No, not what you think. What did you see?

Drew: He definitely, definitely had her on the ground.

Mel: On the ground?

Drew: Right.

Mel: What do you mean he had her there?

Drew: Stop. Stop interrogating me. This is hard.

Mel: (*She realizes how angry she is, and pulls back to try to help him.*) I know sweetie. I know.

Drew: I almost didn't tell you - or anyone.

Mel: Well... you did. You will.

Drew: I did see something.

Mel: And that's why you have to say something.

Drew: Right. That's how it works.

Mel: This is about you. And us. Our future.

Drew: How can you say that? It's about coach, and the team. Those 12 guys. They're counting on him to put them on the right path.

Mel: Well what about that girl's future?

Drew: She looked fine.

Mel: Did she really?

Drew: No. I couldn't see.

Mel: Why were you even in there?

Drew: I forgot my phone. It was 20 minutes after practice, everyone's usually long gone from the court. I may not have even seen them, only the emergency lights were on. But I heard her.

Mel: She said something.

Drew: "No."

Mel: She didn't say anything.

Drew: No, no, she said, "No."

Mel: How many times?

Drew: A lot. I think. Well, depends what "a lot" means. More than once.

Mel: I can't believe you saw this.

Drew: Whatever I saw.

Mel: Wennum is a bastard. He was on top of that girl, that little girl, and she was telling him no.

Drew: You're mad at him now, because you think she said no? Even though I'm not sure I heard it.

Mel: What did you just say! That's what you just said.

Drew: I don't know what I said.

Mel: You have to tell them.

Drew: No.

Mel: What if that was Leyla?

Drew: Don't say that. Our daughter wouldn't let that happen.

Mel: How dare you!

Drew: Leyla would not be that stupid.

Mel: How can *you* be so stupid?

Drew: I've been taught to be that stupid. I've been taught that people can learn what's right and wrong. I was taught that if you gave yourself to a greater thing, a program, you would make stronger people. People who can take care of themselves and their families.

Mel: Well you are not that person. You are not taking care of you family, if you let this happen. Coach is taking care of you, and your family. You are his little squeaking child. An infant, letting him make all the decisions for you.

Drew: That's what Coach is good at! He's there to make the decisions. Remember that time he drove all the way to _ to get Marion out of jail?

Mel: You've only told the story twenty-two times.

Drew: I was in that pickup with him. He did 90 for three hours to get there. All he kept saying to me is, "We can't let this one get away from us." He still had hope, for Marion. And you know only he saw it. I would have left him in that jail, for stealing a damn Xbox. How dumb can you be? But Coach was willing to keep him, even though he'd be suspended for a year and take up one of our scholarship spots. He went in there and you know, that police officer, he'd never seen anyone stand up for a black kid like that. Coach said to him, "You don't know this kid. And that's ok. It's not your job to know him. But it's my job to know him, know him better than he knows himself. And I tell you he's not one of the bad ones." They let him out.

Mel: He did do the right thing there.

Drew: Exactly. That night when the four of us were in the motel, I thought, this is why I wanted to do this.

Mel: Four of you?

Drew: Well, Nisha was with us, Marion's girlfriend. She's the one who told us what happened.

Mel: She went with you.

Drew: Yes, she insisted. Coach too.

Mel: Whose room was she in?

Drew: Oh no, don't worry. I didn't stay with her!

Mel: No. Whose room was she in.

Drew: Well, we couldn't buy a room for Marion and Nisha... that wouldn't have been responsible.

Mel: So she stayed with coach.

Drew: Uh huh.

Mel: Didn't Marion break up with her right after that.

Drew: He did. He said she had... messed around. You're not thinking Coach was involved there too, are you?

Mel: Jesus, how could you not tell me that, either? What else are you hiding?

Drew: I'm not hiding anything. I'm telling you everything.

Mel: I'm sorry. But you are hiding it whether you know it or not. I know it's hard.

Drew: It doesn't have to be hard.

Mel: Yes it does. It is. Even if you lie, even if you never say anything, it will never be easy. This is not the easy way out.

Drew: Not for me. But for the team - those men on the team -

Mel: And the girls?

Drew: It's too late for them.

Mel: That's so selfish.

Drew: You know what? If you're so sure, you report it yourself.

Mel: What?

Drew: There's a security camera in the gym. You can tell our security service to look at it. It's off campus, for this reason. No bias.

Mel: You want me to do this for you? You want me to be a human being so you can be a cowardly soldier for this man?

Drew: Here's the number. All the tips are anonymous.

Mel: You are smaller than I thought. You are not the man I married.

Drew: Maybe not. I tried, but maybe not.

Mel: They won't even believe me.

Drew: If you say what tape to look at, and when, they have to look. The people at the other end don't work here. You don't have to say who you are.

Mel: Then why don't you do it?

Drew: I'd prefer you didn't say who you were. I'm going to go tuck our daughter in.

Mel: Don't even think about leaving this room! You are going to stand here -

(*Drew leaves. Mel is still furious, but dials.*)

Mel: Yes, I have something to report. (*pause*) Anonymously. (*pause*) Wyoming. (*pause*) It's at –

(*Drew returns, angry. He grabs the phone*.)

Drew: Hang it up! Hang it up!

(*Mel yelps in pain. He hurt her hand as he grabbed the phone*.)

Drew: I can't believe you would go through with it.

Mel: You knew who I was when we got married. Although I didn't know you, it seems.

Drew: It doesn't seem like it. You put family first, then. Now it's about... some vague thing. Justice. Who are you to decide? Who are you to put your conscious before our family?

Mel: You hurt me.

Drew: I'm sorry. I'm angry.

Mel: You don't know what anger is.

Drew: I don't?

Mel: My father knew.

Drew: Oh Christ.

Mel: My father knew anger when his little girl got hurt.

Drew: What do you mean?

Mel: I mean when I was in college, I was assaulted.

Drew: Now I'm going to hear THIS? I cannot believe this. You would hide this from me?

Mel: You know nothing. See, you think you know everything, but you know nothing.

Drew: Not when people lie to me.

Mel: The way you have lied to me! The way you want to lie to everyone about Coach!

Drew: What happened to you, tell me right now.

Mel: Since you know everything, you know the story. A boy older than me, by a year. A friend from Reading Squad, someone who led our outreach to schools. It was at a party.

Drew: Did he rape you?

Mel: Yes. He forced himself on me.

Drew: And you said no?

Mel: He knew he wasn't doing the right thing.

Drew: Right. And what did you do?

Mel: I told my dad.

Drew: But did you tell the school? Did you turn him in?

Mel: Thanks for asking about me.

Drew: Well here you are. You're fine. You must be fine, you didn't even tell me about it.

Mel: I told my dad and we made sure the boy knew never to come near me again.

Drew: Oh, I see.

Mel: What?

Drew: You didn't tell anyone else. You did exactly what you don't want me to do. You shielded your little group.

Mel: We were doing something very important. And I knew I was the only one.

Drew: You were sure.

Mel: I was sure. That stupid boy loved me.

Drew: Well, then.

Mel: I was wrong. And this situation is different. Coach could have a dozen girls that's he's...

Drew: Or maybe just one. Maybe he loved her.

Mel: No. That's not what you saw.

Drew: You weren't there. You didn't see it.

Mel: Tell me what you would have needed to see.

Drew: I would have had to walk right up and see it, and ask them, is this ok? Are you both ok?

Mel: You wanted them to walk with you, you wanted Coach to turn himself in. Like he would do that.

Drew: He would. (*lighting up*) Wait, he would. Coach would know when to do the right thing, when he had made a mistake.

Mel: Now that doesn't make any sense.

Drew: I'll talk to him. I will talk to him, and he will make the right choice. He'll turn himself in, to the university, to the police.

Mel: What makes you so sure?

Drew: He just needs to hear it. If he hears it, he will see his actions in the proper light, and it will be

obvious that he needs to change. I just have to show it to him.

Mel: What if he doesn't do the right thing?

Drew: I don't know.

Mel: It shouldn't be up to him.

Drew: It's up to me.

Mel: It shouldn't be up to anyone. If he raped that girl, he has to be made responsible.

Drew: I will talk to him.

Mel: When?

Drew: Next week, when we're back from the preseason tournament. I want the boys to have a good start to the season.

Mel: When you're back from the tournament! But there will be so many chances, and you might change your mind, and oh - I can't even list all the things wrong with that.

Drew: It's the only choice I can make. Just like you could only tell your father, I can only tell coach. It's the only choice, for me.

Mel: I might have to make my own choice, now.

Drew: (s*taring at her, finally with compassion*) I understand that.

Mel: Ok.

Drew: Ok. Ok. This time, I'm really leaving. You call if you want to. I won't ask you either way.

Mel: Ok.

Drew: Goodnight.

(*He leaves. Mel stares at the phone for a long time, holding it in her hand. She grows angrier, and angrier, whether at herself, or Drew, or Coach, is unclear. She may be about to dial or throw the phone away. At the peak of her rage, blackout. The play is over*.)